

# The Internet

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## I. THE INTERNET

### A. Internet Cultural Model

Based on the lecture, we know the Hutchins' views of distributed cognition sees that thinking doesn't only happen within the confines of our minds but is distributed across people, physical objects, and other systems that carry information [1]. If we specifically look at the early years of the Internet, we identify the same principle. There were no separation between the user or the computer with cognition. The people used computers and websites to share and process information, and all of this formed one big network that is recognized as distributed cognition. The early days of the Internet can be seen as an amalgamation of culture, like how Shore's ideas described it. It was made up of many cultural models from different groups of people. Programmers built it using the culture of engineering and logic. Users brought to it individuality through personalization, such as background, language, and belief. Businesses introduced a culture of marketing and money. Many cultures were brought together to ultimately form the model of the Internet. People used the Internet in very different ways depending on where they were and what they believed.

### B. Laird's Standard Model of Cognition

Laird's Standard model explains that intelligence from systems can be broken down and looked at with different parts doing different tasks, such as perception, memory, learning, and decision making [4]. Looking at the Internet in a similar mindset, we can see that the Internet itself works similarly to a mind in which each part does certain specified tasks. The search engines have complete control over what information is given to the people, which would be perception. All the data that is held within servers that are displayed on websites would be the memory aspect of the mind. And finally, algorithms are the core behind different procedures which handles the decision making. Cultural models helps influence the Internet and affect how all the parts of the system focuses on. The Internet's behavior would be reflected from human culture and this would affect how websites are made, what sites are used, what are searched, and even what the Internet is used for.

## II. THE DEAD INTERNET THEORY

### A. Internet in 2030 be alive?

Based on the given scenario, if by 2030, almost everything on the Internet is created by AI, it would be difficult to

determine if the Internet can still be considered "alive" under Hutchins' definition of cognition [1]. There can be arguments for both sides; however, personally I believe that the Internet could not be considered alive. Hutchins' ideas say that thinking happens wherever information is shares and used, which could be said to still be happening in this context. But the meaning behind that information would not be present. Without humans, there would be no intention or purpose behind the actions of the Internet. This would result in a machine that runs and operates without any true understanding of the data. Despite functionality continuing, it cannot be said that the cognition of the Internet is intact and it can't be seen as alive. Real cognition involves people working together and having meaning behind actions, which this scenario's Internet is not able to recreate.

### B. Tomasello's Model

Tomasello's model explains that human culture grows over time because it is built through the evolution of ideas. People learn from each other, which improve ideas, and then passes down to others. This encompasses the model of culture through the idea of cultural ratchet [3]. This idea works because humans share intentions and other build upon what others have already done. In the scenario, even if bots make up almost all the content on the Internet, they would mainly be copying and redo a lot of the content that is already online. The bots don't really understand or care about the meaning and would focus solely work on pumping out content. The bots will essentially keep culture moving in a circular fashion by recycling the popular content from previous times, without no real progress. So the Internet may look like there's plenty of new content from the bots, but it wouldn't be a living culture, just simply a loop of repeated content.

## III. WAR OF THE WORLDS

### A. Re-embodiment

In this new scenario, the bots have now invaded our physical spaces through augmented reality, which begs the questions of whether it makes the Internet alive. Hutchins' previous ideas implies that people and tools work together in reality, and since the bots can now physically interact with people then technically this would consider the Internet to be alive. However, there is still a separation between alive and the current state the Internet would be in. Just because the bots are able to physically interact with the real world does not mean they are alive. They need to be able to cooperate with humans,

learn from them and respond to their goals. Even with physical capabilities they still lack the ability to project intentions and think with us. The Internet would only be called alive again if it is able to think within the real world and coordinate this with humans.

#### *B. Embodied Bots Contribution to Culture*

Now continuing with this scenario, if we look at Tomasello's idea of the cultural ratchet that says that human culture grows over time, we can see that what the embodied bots need to be able to contribute would be the shared intentions behind the content [3]. Tomasello mentions that culture grows when people come together and learn from one another and develop the culture. Although bots have the physical ability to do everything mentioned, they are still not able to connect with humans socially and emotionally. Without that connection, they might be interactive, but they wouldn't really join the cultural ratchet that keeps human culture evolving. Bots need to understand emotions and context to begin the process of teaching and learning that goes hand in hand with culture.

#### REFERENCES

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